Monday Nite Footballers Predictions

By Jim Nunnelly

Championship Predictions

Jacksonville vs. New England Green Bay vs. Carolina

MEMBER	AFC CHAMPION	NFC CHAMPION
Charles Allen	Jacksonville	Carolina
Paul Booker	New England	Green Bay
Ike Gardner	Jacksonville	Green Bay
Ollie Hubbard	Jacksonville	Green Bay
Walt Livingston	New England	Green Bay
Jim Nunnelly	New England	Green Bay
Ed West	Jacksonville	Green Bay

Post Season Advice To The Chiefs: BECOME AN EXPANSION TEAM

It seems only yesterday when everyone in Kansas City was talking about the Chiefs. Coming off a 13-3 record in 1995, and feeling like we were just a step away from the New Orleans Bowl, we bought up all the red sweat shirts, missed church on Sundays and bragged about our Chiefs, as if we had become the mecca for the National Football League.

And, then it was here...the 1996 season. And, bam...off to a 4-0 start and even after eleven games, we had managed to win eight...some in the last minute and a couple in overtime. But, we were winning, and New Orleans was still in our radar.

And after that, things went downhill. Even the ever-venerable defensive led by Neal and Derrick and Tracy, began to crumble. Players began to talk openly. Some even accused the marquee players of being more interested in lucrative commercials, business interests, and good times rather than playing football. What used to be Super Bowl pursuit became a barely audible cry for the playoffs. You know, we didn't even make that, losing to Buffalo.

What is the answer and what advice should we tell the Chiefs as they prepare for San Francisco, Carolina, Jacksonville, St. Louis, and Miami in 1997? Not to speak about Denver, San Diego and maybe a new improved Seattle.

Here is our advice:

QUARTERBACK: Jeff George is available. Take him. It's better than nothing (Bono). We now know we can't make the playoffs without an effective quarterback.

DEFENSIVE END: Neil Smith is about to go on Medicare. The 1996 season was his worst and it signals a coming decline. For once, the Chiefs should get ahead of the parade rather than behind it.

RUNNING BACK: Congratulations to management for announcing that Greg Hill will replace Medicare Marcus. Ike Gardner questions the wisdom of doing this so early mainly because it may dampen the preseason competition. Maybe you're right Ike. But, at least, we made a move.

OFFENSIVE TACKLE: John Alt should join the NASA space team. The Chiefs offensive line is falling down.

RECEIVERS: We let Willie Davis go to Houston and we've been struggling ever since. The early season injury to Lake Dawson didn't help matters. Chris Peen tried. LaChapelle is overrated. So, our advice, get two top receivers from the draft or the free agency pool.

DEFENSIVE SECONDARY: Hold the line here. Help Mark Collins get over his mad spell. Continue to work with Hasty, send Stargell home. And, start looking real seriously at our linebackers. May need some new faces here.

COACHING AND MANAGEMENT: Well, Carl Peterson has been here eight years and he has put the hope back into Kansas City. He hired Marty, prayed for Joe Montana, and sold out Arrowhead week after week. But for some reason, there has been no announcement that he has been rehired. Obviously, it's Carl's call. He can go anywhere he wants. After all, he did turn the franchise around. Owners, fans, and the front office staff are happy. We'll see. Come on Lamar, tell us...is he in or out?

Well, that brings us to hard-headed Marty. While Marty cannot be blamed for the sub-mediocre performance of his players. He can, however, get them out of the game before they hurt the chances of winning. He can revise the whole play-calling process. And he can stop telling us we're "Super Bowl ready" when obviously we're not. Clark, Booker, Ed West and Walt Livingston have doubts about Ol' Marty. But, consensus says Marty will stay and realistically address some of the concerns the fans have raised.

FINAL COMMENTARY: Most of us in the Monday Nite Footballers have watched a dozen or so coaches promise the rain and deliver raindrops. We've seen the defense carry the offense. We've seen a packed and empty Arrowhead. All of this leads us to why we are fans. We love these Chiefs like parents love their children. Very unconditional. Good or bad. Under or over. Behind or in front. We are going to be there for these Kansas City Chiefs. Are we going to stop talking about them? NO. Are we going to remind them of the failed Super Bowl return promise?

YES. Are we going to sit in subzero weather next year to see a possible promise turn sour. YES! YES! YES!

And now, one final piece of advice. Since we're still trying to get to the Super Bowl, it is possible we need to take a look at the two-year expansion teams, Jacksonville and Carolina. They both seem to have the ingredients to expedite and implement a sound plan...maybe Kansas City ought to become an expansion team.

Then everybody, including the players, would be happy!

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